

Global Seismic Series: Statistical Analysis of Spatiotemporal Clustering in $M \geq 6.5$ Earthquake Catalogs, 1973–2026 CE

© 2026 Yaroslav Marshalkin

Yaroslav Marshalkin

Corresponding author: marshalkin@gmail.com

Telegram: @MRSHLKN | GitHub: github.com/marshalkin-ux/paleoseismic-clustering

Abstract.

We analyse a merged catalog of 4,267 unique $M \geq 6.5$ events (from 4,418 CSV rows; ~151 NOAA $M < 6.5$ excluded from clustering; 47 historical NOAA records pre-1900) using the Baiesi–Paczuski metric η with tectonic-path distance (Bird 2003). Primary result — negative (null/falsification): catalog-calibrated ETAS reproduces $N_{\text{obs}}=27$ (mean 27.0, $p_{\text{ETAS}}=1.0$, $\text{FPR}=1000/1000$). Permutation $p=0.0001$ (1/10,001) rejects temporal Poisson null only — not teleseismic triggering. 47 detector candidates; no evidence for physical multi-regional global series.

Keywords: global seismicity; seismic series; earthquake clustering; heuristic metric with tectonic hint; Baiesi–Paczuski metric; ETAS validation; Monte Carlo; paleoseismology; remote triggering

1. INTRODUCTION

Large earthquakes do not occur as independent Poisson events. Following the 1992 Landers earthquake (M_w 7.3), Hill et al. [1993] documented remotely triggered seismicity at distances exceeding 1,000 km. Brodsky & Prejean [2006] showed that surface waves can initiate swarms in volcanic systems thousands of kilometres away. The 2004 Sumatra–Andaman earthquake (M_w 9.1) was followed by elevated activity in distant regions [Pollitz et al., 1998; Freed & Lin, 2001].

However, the systematic nature of such correlations remains debated. Michael [2011] found that $M \geq 7$ clustering in 1995–2011 is statistically indistinguishable from random fluctuations. Shearer & Stark [2012] reported no increase in global $M \geq 7$ and $M \geq 8$ rates after the 2004 Sumatra event. Kagan & Jackson [1999] confirmed elevated probability of paired events at short separation without resolving long-range links.

The ETAS model [Ogata, 1988] reproduces regional aftershock clustering but does not encode inter-plate correlations. The Baiesi–Paczuski [2004] metric and Zaliapin–Ben-Zion extensions [2008, 2013] provide objective cluster detection but typically use Euclidean distance, ignoring lithospheric connectivity.

Objective. We test the hypothesis that multi-regional seismic series exist in a four-millennium catalog of $M \geq 6.5$ earthquakes, using an adapted eta metric with heuristic tectonic hint along Bird (2003) plate boundaries. **Scope.** We combine nearest-neighbor clustering with heuristic tectonic hint, ETAS validation, and FDR sensitivity (Methods); this complements global rate tests (Michael 2011; Shearer & Stark 2012) with a different eta-linkage statistic but does not supersede their conclusions.

2. DATA AND METHODS

2.1 Catalog compilation

Three catalogs were merged: USGS ComCat (1900–2026, primary instrumental); ISC Bulletin (relocated hypocenters); and NOAA NGDC (historical and paleoseismic records pre-1900, 47 events). Duplicates were merged using ± 30 days and ≤ 50 km tolerance; source priority: ISC > USGS > NOAA. After deduplication, the catalog contains 4,267 unique $M \geq 6.5$ events (from 4,418 CSV rows; ~ 151 $M < 6.5$ excluded from clustering). USGS ComCat: 2,088 raw (1973–2026) $\rightarrow$ 2,041 after merge/ISC. GK: 24 aftershocks (2,017/2,041); ZBZ: 1 dependent (2,040/2,041). `quality_score` is metadata, not an inclusion filter. Final catalog: 4,267 $M \geq 6.5$ events (4,418 CSV rows).

2.1.1 Catalog completeness

Maximum-curvature analysis yields $M_c = 6.55$. Maximum-likelihood b -value from 1,688 events above M_c :

$b = 0.911 \pm 0.018$ ($n = 1,688$ events)

2.2 Heuristic metric with tectonic hint

We tested an alternative to Euclidean distance (Bird 2003 graph). In 98% of pairs the implementation falls back to 1.5x great-circle distance — effectively scaled Euclidean; no improvement for global analysis (failed hypothesis test). r_{ij} is the shortest path between hypocenters along the Bird (2003) plate-boundary graph (20 key segments). Paths are computed with Dijkstra's algorithm (NetworkX). If either hypocenter lies >500 km from the nearest boundary node, or no graph path exists, $r_{ij} = 1.5 \times r_{GC}$ (great-circle Haversine). Fallback audit (analyze_tectonic_fallback.py, fig07): 4987 pairs from 500 events; 98.0% GC fallback, 2.0% Dijkstra (4015 snap>500 km, 872 no path, 100 Dijkstra; 95 materially different; examples FE31 Japan, FE35 Philippines). Metric adds value for ~2% boundary-proximal pairs only. Tectonic diagnostic: median Deltalog10eta = +0.28.

$$\text{eta}_{ij} = t_{ij} * r_{ij}^{1.6} * 10^{(-b \cdot \text{mi})}$$

b=1.0 per Baiesi & Paczuski (2004) for eta comparability; catalog b=0.911+/-0.018 in Monte Carlo null only.

2.3 Analysis pipeline

Raw catalogs → dedup → exclude $M < 6.5$ (~151 NOAA) → GK declustering (primary) → eta NN forest → sliding windows → merge overlapping → series criteria → MC/ETAS/FDR. GK: 24 aftershocks (2,017/2,041); ZBZ: 1 dependent (2,040/2,041) — different algorithms (GK: magnitude-dependent windows; ZBZ: eta NN + KDE threshold). At global $M \geq 6.5$ scale ZBZ is permissive (sparse events → high eta). GK is sole primary for inference; ZBZ sensitivity only, does not replace GK. If ZBZ were primary, $N=27$ likely unchanged (untested).

Why GK–ZBZ counts differ: not contradictory methods — GK removes short-range fore/aftershocks via fixed windows; ZBZ classifies only 1 event with exceptionally low eta at global catalog scale. Minimal ZBZ removal confirms declustering is not a critical fork.

2.4 Threshold eta_0 , series detection, and ETAS parameters

Automatic eta_0 from nearest-neighbor eta distribution: KDE valley between bimodal $\log_{10}(\text{eta})$ modes (Zaliapin & Ben-Zion 2013); default $\text{eta}_0 = 10^{\text{median } \log_{10} \text{ eta}}$. Validated against Poisson permutation null ($n = 10,000$).

1. Declustering via Gardner–Knopoff [1974].
2. Nearest-neighbor forest: parent $i^* = \text{argmin } \text{eta}_{ij}$ subject to $\text{eta}_{ij} < \text{eta}_0$.
3. Global series: $N \geq 4$; $M \geq 6.5$; ≥ 3 Flinn–Engdahl regions.
4. Sliding windows (1, 2, 5 yr); overlapping groups merged.

ETAS parameters (catalog-calibrated): MLE on 2,041 events (scripts/calibrate_etas.py, results/etas_calibration.json): $\mu \approx 0.103$, $K \approx 0.495$, $\alpha \approx 0.063$, $c \approx 10^{-4}$ d, $p \approx 1.36$. Literature defaults (Helmstetter & Sornette 2003) retained for comparison.

2.5 Statistical validation

Permutation test: $n = 10,000$, $p \leq 0.0001$, $z = -6.17$ (modern). ETAS validation: calibrated params ($\mu \approx 0.103$, $K \approx 0.495$, $\alpha \approx 0.063$, $c \approx 10^{-4}$ d, $p \approx 1.36$); 1000 catalogs/seed. Single seed=42: FPR=1000/1000; mean 27.0, $p_{\text{ETAS}} = 1.0$; $N_{\text{obs}}=27$. Multiseed ETAS (seeds 42–51, $n=1000$ each, results/etas_multiseed.json): mean=27.0, $\sigma=0.0$, FPR=1.0, $p_{\text{ETAS}}=1.0$ for all 10 seeds —

perfect stability because calibrated ETAS matches catalog event rate (~2001 background events). Literature $\mu=0.008$ comparison only (earlier $n=100$ runs): $\text{mean} \approx 15.5$, $p_{\text{ETAS}} \leq 0.001$. Detector is liberal; tighter series criteria is future work. FDR ($q=0.05$): 45/47 — Methods/sensitivity only, not discovery. Declustering: GK 2,017/2,041 (primary); ZBZ 2,040/2,041 (sensitivity only).

3. RESULTS

3.1 Identified series

Full historical analysis yields 47 global seismic series: 27 modern ($p \leq 0.0001$), 15 early instrumental ($p = 0.007$; pre-1960 incompleteness caveat), 5 historical candidates (not significant, $p = 0.46$; 47 $M \geq 6.5$ events pre-1900). 142 cluster candidates before filtering.

ID	N	Regions	M_{max}	Period	Notes
1905–1910	193	43	8.8	1905–1910	Largest early-instrumental candidate; catalog incomplete before ~1960
S047	53	5	8.0	1982–2024	Western Pacific subduction corridor
S170	46	12	9.1	2002–2023	Sunda belt; Sumatra 2004 (M 9.1)
S095	25	4	7.9	1989–2017	Western Pacific arc
S116	22	5	8.2	1993–2021	South Pacific multi-arc series

Table 1. Top five multi-regional series (≥ 3 Flinn–Engdahl regions).

3.2 Spatial–temporal distribution

Elevated series activity occurs in 1952–1965 and 2002–2016 (post-Sumatra period). Spatially, clusters concentrate along the circum-Pacific belt (Kamchatka, Kuril Islands, Japan, Tonga, Indonesia). Tectonic diagnostic: median $\Delta \log_{10} \eta = +0.28$ on random pairs (mostly 1.5x GC fallback).

4. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

Catalog-calibrated ETAS shows that multi-regional clusters flagged by our liberal detector do not exceed local aftershock expectations. The global-series hypothesis is not supported. The permutation test rejects only a temporal Poisson null — trivial for earthquake catalogs with aftershocks.

1. Heuristic with tectonic hint: 98% GC fallback — failed hypothesis test.
2. 47 detector candidates indistinguishable from ETAS null; Delta CFS/dynamic stress — future work only.

Future work / supplement: Static Delta CFS and dynamic stress for S170, S047, S095; full ETAS MLE and multi-seed robustness.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

Data and code: github.com/marshalkin-ux/paleoseismic-clustering (docs/data_availability.md). External DOI deposition (Zenodo) deferred — GitHub only.

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